



Livewire: Shahbaz Ahmed of Pakistan, a dynamic force in attack, showcased his touch-tap-dribble skills to dismantle defences during the 1990 Hockey World Cup in Lahore. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

has become an expensive sport. Travel costs have soared, and equipment — shoes, sticks, and other gear — is now costly. Unlike other nations, we lack a system where talent-hunting programmes provide proper accommodation or hockey hostels for young players.

When I visited Bhubaneswar a few years ago, I was amazed by the state-of-the-art facilities at the stadium. It was a world-class venue. Whoever takes charge in Pakistan must prioritise developing such venues with complete infrastructure.

Hosting major tournaments is key. When international events take place at home, young players learn far more by watching top-level competition than by reading about it.

Pakistan failed to qualify for the last three Olympics and two of the last three World Cups. Does that hurt?

It's hard to put my feelings into words. Whenever our teams play — even in friendlies — I struggle to watch. It breaks my heart.

When I saw the 2021 Olympic final, I realised the standard wasn't particularly high, yet Pakistan wasn't

even there. That hurt even more. When we played, the game's quality was far superior — it's simply not comparable to today.

But I don't blame the players. This is a failure of investment and legacy-building, not individual effort.

That said, things can improve. Government backing and visionary

leadership are crucial. We need a technocrat who understands an athlete's struggles and can manage the calendar to bring long-term benefits. If these changes happen, hockey has a future. I'd be happy to help the government or any organisation working to revive the sport. I can share my experience

Grand welcome: Star forward Shahbaz Ahmed (wearing spectacles) and captain Tahir Zaman (right) arrive at the Indira Gandhi International Airport on March 17, 1998, ahead of the Test series against India. Pakistan won the eight-Test series 4-3, with one game ending in a draw. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

